VII

PART SEVEN · ◈

The Twelve Dominions

The Dominion Act of 2044 reorganized the states into twelve Dominions by region and economic function. Each has a seat city renamed from an American one, a Governor-Prelate, and a culture that's sometimes Imperial on the surface and sometimes all the way through.

1 · Aurem · Aurelia 520

2 · Gulf · Port Seraphine 522

3 · Ardenne · Ashford 524

4 · Meridian · Blessed Shore 526

5 · Vane · Saint Meridian 528

6 · Irongate · Iron Benediction 529

7 · Heartland · Providence Cross 531

8 · Red Earth · Canaan's Gate 532

9 · Lone · Covenant Basin 534

10 · Mountain · Crestfall 535

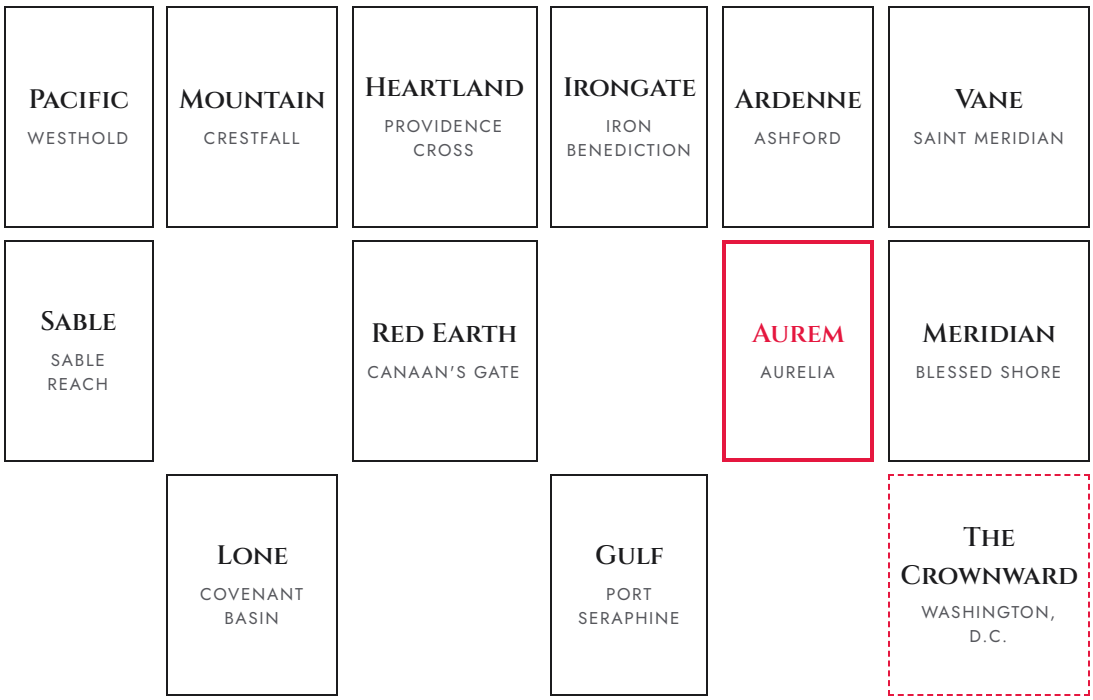
11 · Sable · Sable Reach 537

TKC: TL · DOM

OPEN QUESTION

Twelve Dominions over the old map

A schematic, west to east. The borders roughly follow the old state lines but not exactly, since some states were absorbed and some were split (TL).



INFERENCE Mississippi, Kansas, Missouri, Louisiana, New Mexico, Nevada and Utah each show up in two Dominions, which fits "some states split." OPEN QUESTION: Washington, Alaska and Hawaii don't appear in any Dominion. Inside Pacific, outside the Empire, or something else?

WHERE WASHINGTON, ALASKA AND HAWAII ARE

Seats and records

TKC: DOM · TR

DOMINION	SEAT (FORMERLY)	TERRITORY	IN THE TRIALS
AUREM	Aurelia (Atlanta)	Georgia, Alabama, Mississippi, Tennessee, South Carolina, North Carolina	15 Anointed Wives in 38 Trials, the most of any Dominion
GULF	Port Seraphine (New Orleans)	Louisiana, the Mississippi Gulf Coast, Florida	Historically penalized for warmth
ARDENNE	Ashford (Charleston, West Virginia)	West Virginia, Virginia, Kentucky, Appalachia	Rarely produces Covenant Daughters
MERIDIAN	Blessed Shore (Philadelphia)	Pennsylvania, Maryland, New Jersey, Delaware	Extremely prepared candidates
VANE	Saint Meridian (New York City)	New York and New England	The legacy Dominion, with the most Anointed Wives after Aurem
IRONGATE	Iron Benediction (Chicago)	Illinois, Indiana, Ohio, Michigan, Wisconsin	Almost always administrative daughters
HEARTLAND	Providence Cross (Kansas City)	Missouri, Kansas, Iowa, Nebraska, Minnesota, the Dakotas	The most theologically fluent
RED EARTH	Canaan's Gate (Oklahoma City)	Oklahoma, Arkansas, eastern Kansas, southwestern Missouri	Often scored mid-pack until it's too late
LONE	Covenant Basin (Houston)	Texas, New Mexico, western Louisiana	Pragmatic about the outcome
MOUNTAIN	Crestfall (Denver)	Colorado, Wyoming, Montana, Idaho, parts of Utah and Nevada	Has never produced an Anointed Wife
SABLE	Sable Reach (Phoenix)	Arizona, Nevada, New Mexico, parts of Utah	"Two Sable women are worth five from anywhere else"
PACIFIC	Westhold (Los Angeles)	California, Oregon, parts of Nevada	Watched before they arrive

Source for this part: DOM, unless tagged otherwise.

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: AURELIA

FORMERLY ATLANTA

Aurem

Aurelia, formerly Atlanta · Georgia, Alabama, Mississippi, Tennessee, South Carolina, North Carolina



IN THE TRIALS	15 Anointed Wives in 38 Trials, the most of any Dominion
DESIGNATION	At 18, by a Vowed officer
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Eden Selah Osei · Aurelia · 21

Atlanta had Black wealth, Black culture, Black education and Black memory built so deep into the city that the Coalition couldn't flatten it without admitting what it was erasing. So the Empire dressed it up and called it restoration. The BeltLine became a ceremonial promenade lined with statues and Broadcast screens. Historic neighborhoods became Stewardwife districts, and Peachtree Street became Covenant Way. Magnolias were planted everywhere because they photograph well and rot slowly. Aurelia is the Empire's favorite mirror, Atlanta wearing somebody else's clothes, and the most surveilled and showcased territory in the Empire (TL).

It's humid from May through October. Storms leave the streets smelling of pine and wet concrete, and the red clay keeps bleeding through the paving. Black culture went deepest underground here and survived most stubbornly. Imperial hymns play on Covenant Way, and something else plays in the outer districts. Food is the main vessel of memory, and the Empire never thought the kitchen was dangerous enough to watch.

Aurem has the highest Commonwife rate and the most elaborate marriage ceremonies in the Empire, on purpose. Its Covenant Daughter gets forty-seven seconds on Sovereign Boulevard in the Opening Procession, more than anyone else, and every girl in Aurem knows that number before she can read. An Aurem candidate is expected to win. Death is the place where "the Empire lost completely and still has no idea."

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

The Salt Ceremony · the old way of burial (the Telling, the Feeding, the Release) · the Speaking · kitchens

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT THE FORTY-SEVEN SECONDS ACTUALLY SHOW, EVERY YEAR

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: PORT SERAPHINE

FORMERLY NEW ORLEANS

GULF

Port Seraphine, formerly New Orleans · Louisiana, the Mississippi Gulf Coast, Florida

SEAL OF GULF · DRAW OR PASTE

IN THE TRIALS	Historically penalized for warmth
DESIGNATION	At 14, the Procession
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Delphine Fontenot · Port Seraphine · 22

New Orleans was never going to be easy. The first Governor-Prelate lasted fourteen months and reported the city "resistant to spiritual reorientation." The Empire settled for managing it. Port Seraphine is loyal enough for the Broadcast and layered enough underground that the Vowed have learned to look away. Hurricane season takes half the year, and the city is "built on water and spite."

Gulf is the most culturally intact Dominion. Music survived here, standing in plain sight, because tourism, rebranded as "cultural pilgrimage," earns too much to lose. Gulf candidates arrive fluent in being watched, and the scoring system has historically penalized them for warmth, which Crown advisors read as performance. A Gulf woman who knows the gap between what she shows and what she keeps is one of the most dangerous women in the room.

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

Music at Bindings · the Last Free Night · the Procession · three-day funerals and the Quiet

WHAT HAPPENED THE YEAR THE EMPIRE TRIED AND FAILED TO STOP THE MUSIC

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT HAPPENED THE YEAR THE EMPIRE TRIED AND FAILED TO STOP THE MUSIC

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: ASHFORD

FORMERLY CHARLESTON, WEST VIRGINIA

Ardenne

Ashford, formerly Charleston, West Virginia · West Virginia, Virginia, Kentucky, Appalachia

SEAL OF ARDENNE · DRAW OR PASTE

IN THE TRIALS	Rarely produces Covenant Daughters
DESIGNATION	Standard in Ashford. Hollow children tested when they can be brought in.
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Maren Cole · Ashford · 23

Appalachia was never fully inside America's idea of itself, and it isn't fully inside the Empire's. Ashford is the city the Empire keeps as proof that Ardenne is pacified, and everything past the tree line says otherwise. It has real winters, hollows that cut communities off from each other and from surveillance, and fog thick enough to hide the next house.

The Ungoverned have their deepest roots here. Outer Ardenne children who get assessed score extraordinarily well, since children raised to solve real problems do well on problem-solving tests. Ardenne rarely sends a Covenant Daughter, and when it does she's usually from Ashford and quiet about the gap. Its Governor-Prelate has mostly stopped trying to fix the marriage records from outside Ashford.

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

Hollow marriages and the broom · the First Winter Work · the Sitting

WHO LEADS THE UNGOVERNED IN THE HOLLOWS, AND WHAT THEY KNOW ABOUT THE CROWNWARD

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO LEADS THE UNGOVERNED IN THE HOLLOWS, AND WHAT THEY KNOW ABOUT THE CROWNWARD

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: BLESSED SHORE

FORMERLY PHILADELPHIA

Meridian

Blessed Shore, formerly Philadelphia · Pennsylvania, Maryland, New Jersey, Delaware



IN THE TRIALS	Extremely prepared candidates
DESIGNATION	Three-day sessions: theology, written reasoning, policy, "relational compliance"
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Corinne Vale · Blessed Shore · 22

The Empire took Philadelphia for its symbolism. The city that held the Declaration of Independence now holds the legal architecture of everything the Declaration claimed to prevent. Blessed Shore houses the Covenant Court's secondary chambers, where the law "gets interpreted, refined, and weaponized."

Meridian absorbed Imperial culture more completely than almost anywhere, because its administrators trust process. Its underground is made of lawyers and bureaucrats filing precise challenges that go nowhere and documenting them for a future someone is preparing. Stewardwives here are expert readers of Binding contracts, trained in Reading Circles. Meridian candidates know every rule and where the gaps are, which makes one who decides to move almost impossible to stop.

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

Reading Circles, since 2069 · a father walks his son through the family record

WHAT THE READING CIRCLES HAVE DOCUMENTED, AND FOR WHOM

WHAT THE READING CIRCLES HAVE DOCUMENTED, AND FOR WHOM

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: SAINT MERIDIAN

FORMERLY NEW YORK CITY

Vane

Saint Meridian, formerly New York City · New York and New England

SEAL OF VANE · DRAW OR PASTE

IN THE TRIALS	The legacy Dominion, with the most Anointed Wives after Aurem
DESIGNATION	At 16, the Broadcast Assessment, partly filmed
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Calla Merritt · Saint Meridian · 21

New York was the hardest cultural conquest and the one the Empire brags about most. It named the whole Dominion after its founding Emperor, which is both honor and leash. Saint Meridian is the Broadcast capital, and the studios that announce Trial scores sit in old Midtown. The skyline stayed, and everything underneath it changed.

The city's density makes surveillance both total and porous, and it has the largest Ungoverned-sympathizer population of any seat city. Vane is the legacy Dominion. Some families have sent Covenant Daughters to three consecutive Trials, and high-scoring girls are prepared for candidacy from the time they can read.

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

Ghost Marriages · the Ghost Declaration

WHICH FAMILIES HAVE SENT DAUGHTERS TO THREE TRIALS RUNNING, AND WHAT IT COST THEM

Irongate

Iron Benediction, formerly Chicago · Illinois, Indiana, Ohio, Michigan, Wisconsin

SEAL OF IRONGATE · DRAW OR PASTE

IN THE TRIALS	Almost always administrative daughters
DESIGNATION	At 14 the Placement, at 18 Imperial Designation
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Nadia Orin · Iron Benediction · 20

Chicago gave the Empire industry and political machinery, which it kept, and music, which it tried to dismantle. Blues and jazz were labeled "morally ambiguous musical forms" in 2053 and went underground. Iron Benediction is the manufacturing heart of the Empire.

Irongate is the most class-divided Dominion, and its labor and administrative districts might as well be different civilizations. The labor-district women run a mutual aid network called the Kitchen that the Vowed have never mapped. Covenant Daughters are almost always administrative daughters, because selection rewards polish and polish costs money. Nadia Orin is the exception, the most working-class Covenant Daughter in Trial history (TR).

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

The Kitchen · the Placement · the First Shift · blues and jazz underground

HOW NADIA GOT THROUGH A SELECTION BUILT FOR POLISH

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: IRON BENEDICTION

FORMERLY CHICAGO

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

HOW NADIA GOT THROUGH A SELECTION BUILT FOR POLISH

Heartland

Providence Cross, formerly Kansas City · Missouri, Kansas, Iowa, Nebraska, Minnesota, the Dakotas

SEAL OF HEARTLAND · DRAW OR PASTE

IN THE TRIALS	The most theologically fluent
DESIGNATION	At 13, the First Covenant, where her track is set in public
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Ruth Gideon · Providence Cross · 22

The Heartland didn't need conquering, because the Coalition had been building here for decades. Providence Cross is the most genuinely loyal seat city in the Empire. People sing the hymns because they mean them.

The sincerity is the Empire's most valuable asset and one of its hardest to control, because real believers have opinions about what faithfulness requires. Some of the Empire's most serious theological debates happen here, including Heartland women's "theological inquiry" into the Commonwife designation. Heartland sends the most theologically fluent Covenant Daughters, for whom devotion is both credential and liability.

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

The Anointing, hair washed and braided · planting after a burial

WHAT RUTH BELIEVES THAT THE EMPIRE WOULD RATHER SHE DIDN'T

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: PROVIDENCE CROSS

FORMERLY KANSAS CITY

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: CANAAN'S GATE

FORMERLY OKLAHOMA CITY

Red Earth

Canaan's Gate, formerly Oklahoma City · Oklahoma, Arkansas, eastern Kansas, southwestern Missouri

SEAL OF RED EARTH · DRAW OR PASTE

IN THE TRIALS	Often scored mid-pack until it's too late
DESIGNATION	At 18, two weeks in Temple spaces, Crown facilities and "domestic simulation environments"
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Delia Cross · Canaan's Gate · 24

Oklahoma's history of land taken and people removed came before the Empire. Canaan's Gate is built over a city that survived the 1995 bombing, and the Empire likes that resilience story. Red Earth piloted the Commonwife quota in 2058, and its women have lived under the full version longest.

It's the most visibly religious Dominion in its architecture and the most privately exhausted, with scripture on every building and the Vowed embedded as "pastoral care." Under the performance runs a language of small signals refined over decades. Red Earth candidates are the best in the Empire at performing compliance while thinking something else. Delia Cross's family was transferred there from Aurem when she was six, and she carries a grudge against the Dominion she left (TR).

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

The Second Covenant · score coaching · sitting with the dead

THREE OF THE SMALL SIGNALS, AND WHAT EACH ONE MEANS

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THREE OF THE SMALL SIGNALS, AND WHAT EACH ONE MEANS

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: COVENANT BASIN

FORMERLY HOUSTON

Lone

Covenant Basin, formerly Houston · Texas, New Mexico, western Louisiana



IN THE TRIALS	Pragmatic about the outcome
DESIGNATION	At 16 in Covenant Basin. The First Ride outside it.
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Vivienne Hale · Covenant Basin · 23

Texas negotiated its surrender. The Empire got the territory and Texas kept the attitude. Covenant Basin runs on oil wealth and space infrastructure. Its Governor-Prelate is always Texas-born and has more independence than any other.

The distances leave real gaps in the surveillance grid, so west Lone is managed through local Vowed officers. People here perform loyalty loudly and then do what they were going to do anyway, and outer-territory women have a practical autonomy that would get them flagged in Aurem. Lone interprets "Ungoverned" loosely and never files a full report. It treats the Trials like any other Imperial requirement.

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

The Giving · the First Ride · burial in boots

WHAT A WEST LONE WOMAN CAN DO THAT WOULD GET HER FLAGGED IN AUREM

Mountain

Crestfall, formerly Denver · Colorado, Wyoming, Montana, Idaho, parts of Utah and Nevada

SEAL OF MOUNTAIN · DRAW OR PASTE

IN THE TRIALS	Has never produced an Anointed Wife
DESIGNATION	At 16, with a physical assessment
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Petra Solano · Crestfall · 22

The Empire wanted the mountains for what's inside them: minerals, military installations, elevation and secrecy. Crestfall is the face, and the mountains are the truth. The classified operations there are the Empire's least documented and most important work: surveillance technology, resource extraction, Temple expansion funding and military capacity.

Crestfall women are the most physically capable in the Empire and among the most watched. Girls selected at Designation for classified Vowed service disappear from public life. Endurance was held in Mountain terrain for Trials 1 through 31, moved to a controlled facility for 32 through 38, and returned for the 39th without explanation. Azrael is hidden here, in a community whose patriarch owes the Vanes a debt (TL). Lyris is from Mountain too (WR).

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

The Witness Walk · the name spoken to the mountain

WHAT DEBT THE PATRIARCH OWES THE VANES, AND FROM WHEN

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: CRESTFALL

FORMERLY DENVER

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT DEBT THE PATRIARCH OWES THE VANES, AND FROM WHEN

SABLE

Sable Reach, formerly Phoenix · Arizona, Nevada, New Mexico, parts of Utah

SEAL OF SABLE · DRAW OR PASTE

IN THE TRIALS	"Two Sable women are worth five from anywhere else"
DESIGNATION	At 18 in Sable Reach. The Finding outside it.
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Zara Voss · Sable Reach · 21 · desert name Tazaleh

The desert resists the Empire the way deserts resist everything, by not caring. Heat destroys equipment, sand gets into everything, and the distances defeat centralized monitoring. Sable Reach is the ornate Imperial city the Empire keeps as proof it can reach hard country. The desert beyond it is where Ungoverned crossings happen.

The desert held civilizations long before the United States, and the Empire renamed the cities but not the land. Women in the outer communities carry plant and land knowledge the Empire has never catalogued. Every Sable woman has two names, one for the Empire and one for the house. Zara Voss's desert name is Tazaleh (TL, TR). INTERPRETATION Sable's two-name custom and Celeste's house name for Eden are the same instinct in two Dominions, and Eden and Zara's name exchange in the middle of the book rests on it.

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

Desert names · the Desert Walk · fire burials

THE SCENE WHERE EDEN AND ZARA EXCHANGE NAMES

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: SABLE REACH

FORMERLY PHOENIX

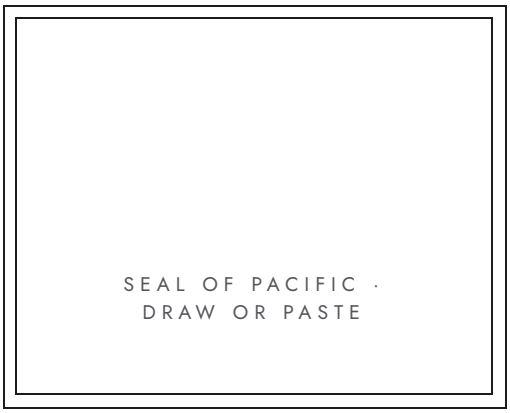
WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE SCENE WHERE EDEN AND ZARA EXCHANGE NAMES

Pacific

Westhold, formerly Los Angeles · California, Oregon, parts of Nevada



IN THE TRIALS	Watched before they arrive
DESIGNATION	At 18. Every score reviewed in the Crownward for inherited resistance.
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Sera Montoya · Westhold · 24

Pacific carries the memory of resistance like scar tissue. The secession attempt and the two-year standoff produced a generation that remembers trying to leave, and their grandchildren know the story. The Empire watches Westhold harder than anywhere: more cameras per block, more loyalty programming, and a Governor-Prelate Dorian appointed personally, who performs warmth while administering iron.

Old Los Angeles's creative industries adapted instead of dying, and people still make what they actually want and pass it through networks the Empire can't map. Every Pacific girl's Designation is reviewed in the Crownward for inherited resistance, and every Pacific Covenant Daughter arrives already flagged.

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

The Real Binding · Facing West · burial facing the ocean

HOW PACIFIC SCHOOLS TEACH THE PARTITION, AND WHAT THE GRANDMOTHERS SAY AT HOME

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: WESTHOLD

FORMERLY LOS ANGELES

YOURS

OPEN QUESTIONS

PART IX LOG

Working Questions

1 · HOW DID AUREM GET FIFTEEN ANOINTED WIVES? WHICH TRIALS, AND DOES AURELIA REMEMBER THEIR NAMES?

2 · WHAT IS THE REAL NAME OF AURELIA'S OUTER DISTRICTS, AND WHAT DO PEOPLE IN SECTOR SEVEN CALL THEIR OWN STREETS?

3 · WHAT DOES EACH GOVERNOR-PRELATE WANT FROM THE 39TH TRIAL?

4 · WHICH DOMINION WOULD EDEN MOST FEAR BEING SENT TO, AND WHY?

5 · WHAT DO PEOPLE IN THE OTHER ELEVEN DOMINIONS THINK OF AUREM, ITS FORTY-SEVEN SECONDS AND ITS FIFTEEN ANOINTED WIVES?

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

5 · WHAT DO PEOPLE IN THE OTHER ELEVEN DOMINIONS THINK OF AUREM, ITS FORTY-SEVEN SECONDS AND ITS FIFTEEN ANOINTED WIVES?

VIII

PART EIGHT · ⌖

The Covenant Trials

A televised selection. Each Dominion sends one Covenant Daughter, and over about four months the Crown Heir's Anointed Wife is chosen from the twelve. The other eleven are married down the elite ladder.

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iii · The Regional Assessment	548
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v · The three phases	552
vi · Scoring	555
vii · The Declaration and its rules	556
viii · The Covenant Daughters of the 39th Trial	558

Revelation, not competition

The Empire presents the Trials as revelation, never as competition, because "a competition can be rigged. A revelation cannot" (TR). The Broadcast's words are anointing, covenant, calling, worthy and chosen. This part covers how the Trials work in any year. What happens in the 39th belongs to Volume Two.

The Trials sit where every earlier part of this companion meets. The Temple runs the first phase and names it Genesis. The Crown runs the second and names it Exodus. The terrain runs the third. A girl is examined on scripture by people who've decided which scripture counts, debated on governance by the heir to a throne her own scripture limits, and sent into the mountains with no cameras by a Broadcast that will reconstruct what happened afterward.

"A competition can be rigged. A revelation cannot."

TR | FR 19–28

THE WEIGHTS

Temple 30 · Crown 30 · Broadcast 40. Never disclosed.

THE OUTPUT

One Anointed Wife for the heir, eleven married down the ladder, nobody sent home unassigned (FR 19).

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Part VI, the Triune Rule and the Binding.

TKC: TL · TR · DOM · FR 30 · FR 34 · FR 39

Thirty-nine Trials

WHEN	WHAT	SOURCE
2048	Elias marries Sera Callum. The first Anointed marriage becomes the template.	TL
2065	Crest introduces the Trials as "a celebration of the Empire's finest women." The first cycle is rough, and the ratings are extraordinary.	TL
22ND TRIAL	Ladies in Waiting introduced, to keep high performers in the Crownward instead of sending them home with influence nobody can manage	TR
TRIALS 1–31	Endurance held in Mountain terrain	DOM
2085	Cancelled after Crest dies mid-cycle and Dorian's accession forces a transition. The twelve go home with their designations intact and no placements.	FR 34, 39
FROM 2085	Under Dorian the Trials become the most-watched event in the Empire's calendar	TL
TRIALS 32–38	Endurance moved to a controlled facility with continuous filming	TR, DOM
2104	The 39th Trial. Endurance returns to Mountain terrain without public explanation.	TR

EVERY YEAR	INFERENCE The Trials run annually. The first was in 2065, and with 2085 skipped, the 39th lands in 2104 (FR 39).
THE 2085 COHORT	They met while being assembled and measured against each other, and they're scattered through their home Dominions now. The shared history makes a network possible, and it doesn't activate before Book Two (FR 34). The 2085 cohort is the thing Hannah has never said out loud (FR 30). INFERENCE She was one of the twelve.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT THE TRIALS WERE LIKE IN THE 2060S AND 2070S, BEFORE DORIAN MADE THEM SPECTACLE

TKC: TR · DR3 · TL · FR 27

The Covenant Registry

Every Dominion keeps a Covenant Registry of women aged 18 to 25 who meet five requirements (**TR**): Unbound or elevated designation, no prior marriage registration, no Ungoverned citations, completion of the standard Imperial curriculum, and "demonstrated covenantal aptitude," which means whatever the Governor-Prelate needs it to mean.

Covenant Registration

AUREM

NOMINATED · BORDERED IN GOLD

CANDIDATE

_____

NOMINATED BY

Vowed officer · family · community leader

FEE

none

NOMINATED

Independent Submission

AUREM

SELF-NOMINATED · PRINTED IN RED

CANDIDATE

Eden Selah Osei

NOMINATED BY

herself

FEE

ten dollars, nonrefundable

INDEPENDENT

SELF-NOMINATION	The Empire frames it as exceptional faith. In practice the process is built to exhaust anyone without institutional support, and most self-nominations fail for that reason alone (**TR**). In Aurem it's "independent submission," a ten-dollar nonrefundable fee and a card printed in red instead of bordered in gold (**DR3**). Eden is the first Aurem candidate in the Trials' history to enter that way (**TL**).
ELIGIBILITY ISN'T ENTRY	A House Mother can submit a name, and she isn't the only one who can (**FR 27**).

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE MORNING EDEN PAID THE TEN DOLLARS

TKC: TR · TL · DR3

Three days, a ranked list

Each Dominion runs a three-day Regional Assessment under senior Vowed officers, which produces a ranked list (**TR**, **TL**).

Regional Assessment · Results

AURELIA TEMPLE ATRIUM

POSTED THE THIRD MONDAY OF JUNE · SEVEN O'CLOCK IN THE MORNING

APPOINTED TO THE COVENANT	*the top five, photographs hung through the summer*
FAMILIES	*formal review, the kind where unpaid levies disappear*
DISCERNMENT · SPIRITUAL FITNESS	*graded by ministerial review*
READ BEFORE THE SCORES	*Proverbs 31.29, King James wording*

POSTED

MINISTERIAL REVIEW	Some sections, like Discernment and Spiritual Fitness, are graded by ministerial review, so a girl can know every answer and still fail for a lack of humility (**DR3**).
THE CHOICE	The Governor-Prelate chooses the Covenant Daughter from the top three. In practice he picks whoever the Crown has quietly signaled it prefers, then documents it as a choice from the top three regardless of the real ranking (**TR**).

WHAT A GIRL'S FAMILY IN AUREM GETS, SPECIFICALLY, WHEN SHE'S APPOINTED

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT A GIRL'S FAMILY IN AUREM GETS, SPECIFICALLY, WHEN SHE'S APPOINTED

TKC: TR · CR · TL · FR 26

Covenant Row

ARRIVAL	The twelve arrive in the first week of summer, staggered across seven days so each arrival can be released as its own day of content. Each travels by Dominion transport with two Appointed Officers and her House Mother (**TR**). Each walks Sovereign Boulevard on camera. The walk is choreographed: what pace to keep, where to look, how to hold her hands (**CR**).
THE HOUSES	Twelve townhouses on Covenant Row, one per Dominion, under five minutes' walk from Sovereign Boulevard. Cameras in every common area, entrance and garden, and not the bedrooms (**CR**). The candidates aren't sequestered. They're embedded in Crownward public life: Temple services, forums, the approved dining rooms, the Administrative Side markets (**CR**).
HOUSE STAFF	In House Aurem, the House Mother, the House Coordinator, the stylist and the Debate and Protocol Advisor (**TL**). A House hosts one Covenant Daughter per Trial, and staff serve across many. Hannah's "six Trials, twelve girls" counts her whole career across several Houses and posts (**FR 26**).

HOUSE AUREM · COVENANT ROW · FLOOR PLAN, DRAW IT

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHERE THE CAMERAS ARE IN HOUSE AUREM, AND THE ONE PLACE EDEN FINDS THAT THEY AREN'T

TKC: TR

Three powers, three questions

The Trials run in three phases. Each belongs to a different power and asks a different question, and they line up with the novel's Genesis, Exodus and Revelation (**TR**).

I · GENESIS

The Covenant Examination

"Who are you?"

THE TEMPLE · WEEKS 1–4

- The Settling
- The Doctrinal Assessment
- The Theological Interview
- The Public Testimony

30%

II · EXODUS

The Governance Trials

"How smart are you?"

THE CROWN · WEEKS 5–10

- The Dominion Forum
- The Civic Debates
- The Anointed Evening
- The Pairing Introduction

30%

III · REVELATION

Endurance

"What are you willing to endure?"

THE TERRAIN · THREE DAYS

- Coordinates to reach
- No schedule
- No handlers
- No cameras after deployment

FEEDS THE BROADCAST'S 40%

SUPERSEDED The original Trials file had four phases: the Covenant Examination, the Governance Trials, the Public Season and the Declaration. **OPEN QUESTION** The original also had candidates sign a confidentiality covenant before the Crown's phase, with removal and a permanent Ungoverned citation for breaking it (**TR-orig**). Does it still exist?

WHICH PHASE EACH OF THE TWELVE IS BUILT TO SURVIVE

What happens in each

TKC: TR

THE SETTLING	Presented as a grace period. It's the most intensive assessment of all, because the Vowed watch everything.
THE DOCTRINAL ASSESSMENT	A six-hour written exam in the Temple Sanctum, set at each candidate's ceiling, so no two girls get the same questions.
THE THEOLOGICAL INTERVIEW	A conversation with a senior Vowed officer, who's told to pursue any rehearsed answer until she finds what's underneath it.
THE PUBLIC TESTIMONY	A fifteen-minute statement of faith and purpose, broadcast live, the first time the Empire hears each candidate unmediated. Candidates are given Vowed handlers to "ensure theological accuracy," and they can decline them.
THE DOMINION FORUM	Every remaining candidate in a room with an Empire-wide crisis and no assigned leader.
THE CIVIC DEBATES	Three filmed debates on governance, theology and social policy, topics given an hour before. The Crown Heir moderates the social policy debate.
THE ANOINTED EVENING	Four hours with the Anointed Court in the Crown Palace, where the cameras can't follow into the side rooms.
THE PAIRING INTRODUCTION	Thirty minutes alone with the Heir, with a Crown advisor and a Vowed officer present and a camera outside the door. The room isn't recorded. The Commission has been known to wire candidates beforehand.
ENDURANCE	What the Empire calls covenantal fortitude and the terrain calls survival. The Broadcast films the deployment and the final checkpoint, and everything between is reconstructed from the candidates' accounts, always incomplete.

A DOCTRINAL ASSESSMENT QUESTION AT EDEN'S CEILING. WRITE ONE

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

A DOCTRINAL ASSESSMENT QUESTION AT EDEN'S CEILING. WRITE ONE

The Evening Reckoning

TKC: TR

Sovereign Boulevard · every evening at seven

The scores update on the screens.

✣

THE EMPIRE NAMED IT THE EVENING RECKONING (**TR**)

THE COMPOSITE	Temple 30 percent, Crown 30 percent, Broadcast 40 percent, never disclosed. The Broadcast's share includes narrative-priority decisions by the Broadcast Director (**TR**).
THE ANTAGONIST NARRATIVE	Every Trial produces one, assigned to the candidate who most threatens a comfortable outcome, and not to the eventual winner (**TR**).
THE EVE PROBLEM	When a candidate's intelligence becomes the story instead of her compliance, the Broadcast calls it internally the Eve problem. The narrative implies and never accuses. It moves the score without changing a single formal assessment, and it has worked every time it's been used (**TR**).

WHAT THE NARRATIVE-PRIORITY DECISION LOOKS LIKE INSIDE THE CITADEL, AND WHO SIGNS IT

TKC: TR · FR 20–25

Sovereign Boulevard, live

After the Endurance rankings are confirmed, the Crown Heir names his Anointed Wife in a public ceremony on Sovereign Boulevard, broadcast live in all twelve Dominions (TR). The rules around that moment come from the Final Rulings.

THE RANKED WINNER · FR 20	The heir may choose any of the twelve. "Without deviation" describes the record, not a rule.
WHAT WINNING MEANS · FR 21	Being the choice that costs the Crown nothing. The rankings tell the heir which selection is free. Deviation is permitted and expensive, and no heir has ever paid it.
REFUSAL · FR 22	The recommendation stands by default once the window closes. Refusing is abstention, not resistance, and produces the same result as complying.
CANCELLATION · FR 23	Impossible once the Trial is announced, except in a public dynastic emergency: the Heir's death or incapacity, or the Emperor's death forcing an immediate transition. A candidate's death doesn't downgrade a Trial.
A CANDIDATE'S DEATH · FR 24	Her status goes back to her family, with no compensation and no punishment, as though the designation had never been made.
REJECTED CANDIDATES · FR 25	Married down as designated. The rejection follows them "not in the record, in the room."
LADIES IN WAITING · TR	The third- and fourth-place Endurance finishers stay in the Crownward in supporting roles to the Anointed Wife and the Crown household.

WHAT THE MEN ASSIGNED TO THE ELEVEN KNOW ABOUT THEIR BRIDES BEFORE THE DECLARATION

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

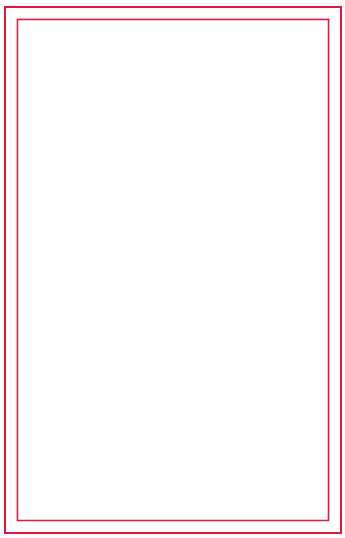
WHAT THE MEN ASSIGNED TO THE ELEVEN KNOW ABOUT THEIR BRIDES BEFORE THE DECLARATION

TKC: TR · RULING

VOLUME TWO, PART III

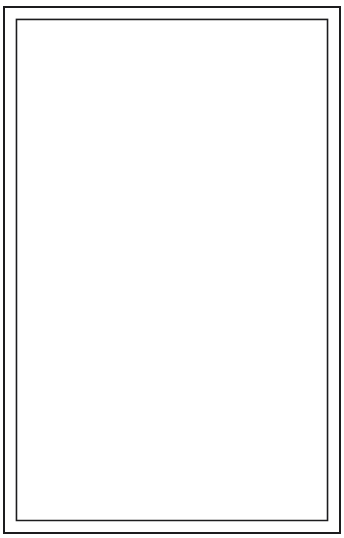
The twelve, I

For reference. Their stories are in Volume Two. Each frame is for a portrait, a Broadcast still, or whatever you draw.



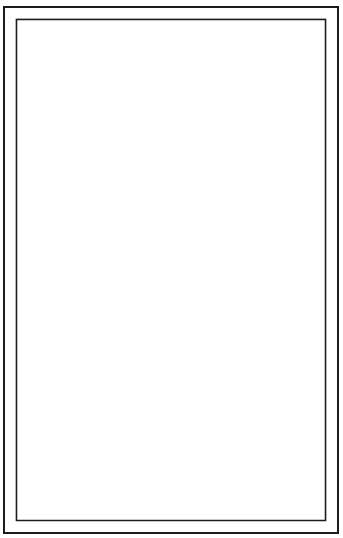
Eden Selah Osei

AUREM · AURELIA · 21



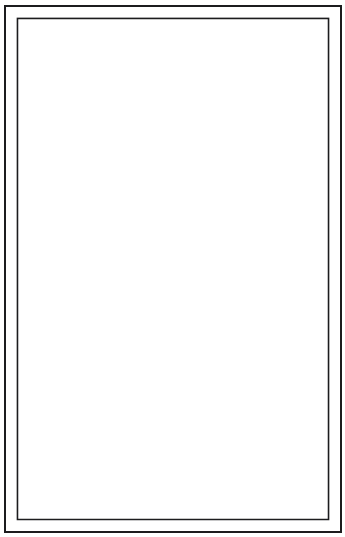
Delphine Fontenot

GULF · PORT SERAPHINE · 22



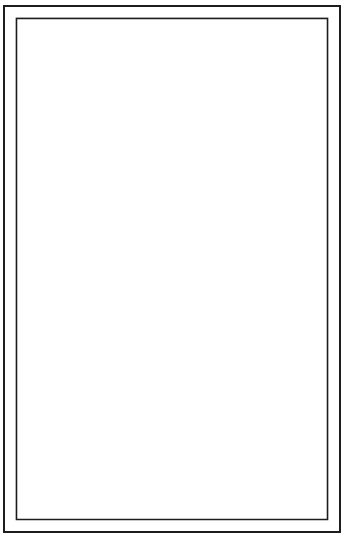
Maren Cole

ARDENNE · ASHFORD · 23



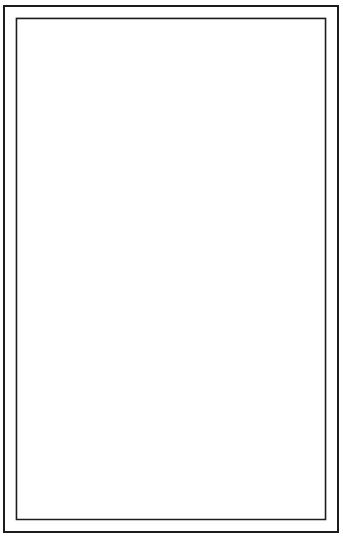
Corinne Vale

MERIDIAN · BLESSED SHORE · 22



Calla Merritt

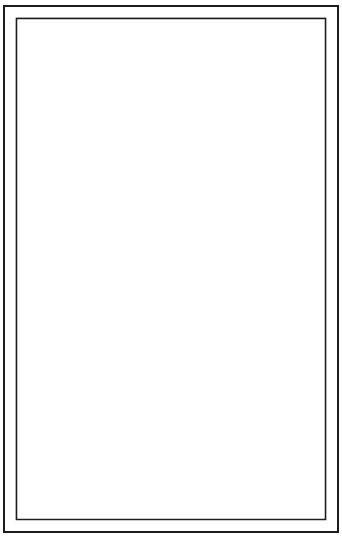
VANE · SAINT MERIDIAN · 21



Nadia Orin

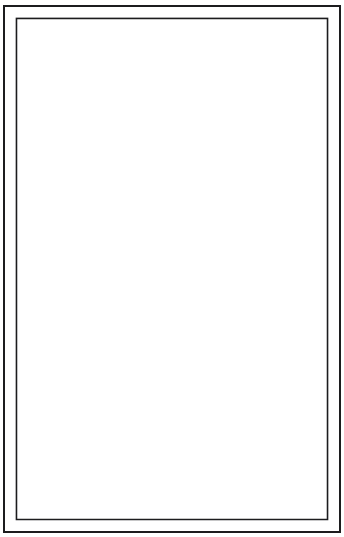
IRONGATE · IRON BENEDICTION · 20

The twelve, II



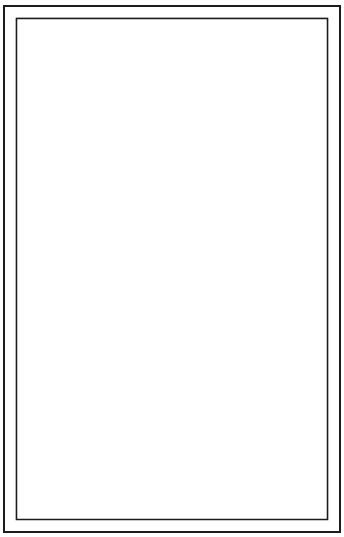
Ruth Gideon

HEARTLAND · PROVIDENCE CROSS · 22



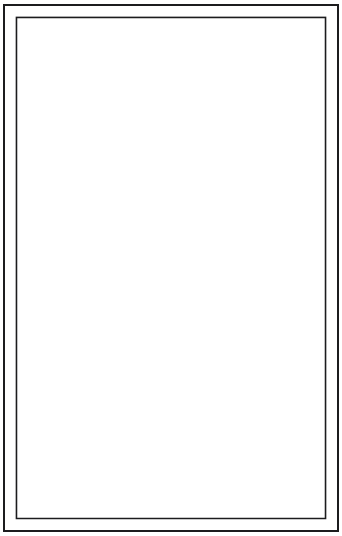
Delia Cross

RED EARTH · CANAAN'S GATE · 24



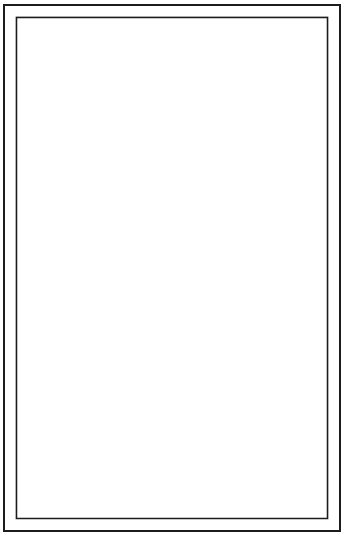
Vivienne Hale

LONE · COVENANT BASIN · 23



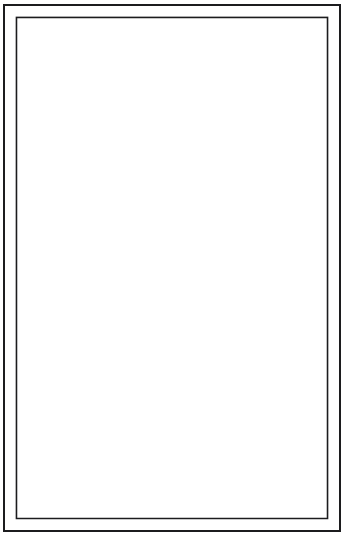
Petra Solano

MOUNTAIN · CRESTFALL · 22



Zara Voss

SABLE · SABLE REACH · 21



Sera Montoya

PACIFIC · WESTHOLD · 24

Calla's surname is from your ruling. Sources: TR, Ruling.

YOURS

OPEN QUESTIONS

PART IX LOG

Working Questions

1 · WHO SITS ON THE TRIALS COMMISSION AND THE OVERSIGHT COMMITTEE, AND ARE THEY THE SAME BODY?

2 · WHAT DO LADIES IN WAITING DO DAY TO DAY, AND WHO HAS HELD THE TITLE?

3 · WHO CHOSE TO BRING ENDURANCE BACK TO MOUNTAIN TERRAIN FOR THE 39TH, AND WHY?

4 · WHAT DOES A HOUSE MOTHER DO ACROSS A CAREER? WHAT HAPPENS TO HOUSE STAFF WHEN THEIR GIRL LOSES?

5 · WHAT HAS HAPPENED TO THE WOMEN THE EVE NARRATIVE WAS USED ON IN EARLIER TRIALS?

6 · HAS A COVENANT DAUGHTER EVER DIED BEFORE PETRA? HOW DID THE EMPIRE HANDLE IT?

BACK MATTER

Register, Sources and Log

What's fixed, what's open, where everything came from, and the record of what you decide next.

The canon register	563
Superseded and in conflict	565
Open questions, gathered	566
The discovery log	568
Sources and editions	572

What's fixed

Everything on this page is canon until you overrule it. The Final Rulings outrank every source file, and your own decisions outrank the rest of this book.

ITEM	RULING	WHERE IT LANDS
SOLOMON'S AGE	**DECIDED** sixteen. The timeline's thirteen is SUPERSEDED.	Part II cast table, Part VI men
LEAH AND EDEN	**DECIDED** Leah is younger than Eden.	Part II cast table
THOMAS	Left voluntarily (**FR 3**)	Part VI Commonwife marriage
MIRIAM	Reassigned after Thomas left (**FR 0**). Celeste has no proof she's alive (**FR 16**).	Part V, Part VI
LEAH'S ASSESSMENT	**DECIDED** Leah sat for an assessment.	Part VI Designation
THE PRELATE	Renamed under FR 33 so Hannah's daughter keeps the name Naomi. **POSSIBLE** working name Aurelia. Never Huldah.	Part VI Temple
CREST	Dorian's uncle (**FR 35**). His claim came through survivorship (**FR 39**).	Parts V, VI
THE REMOVED HEIR	Elias's elder child, Dorian's parent, removed in 2061 (**FR 35–36**)	Part V
DORIAN	59 in 2104 (**Ruling**)	Parts V, VI
CALLA'S SURNAME	Merritt (**Ruling**)	Part VIII
CHILDREN'S STATUS	By household registration, not parentage (**FR 32**)	Part VI
THE ELEVEN	Married down the elite ladder. Nobody goes home unassigned (**FR 19**).	Parts VI, VIII
DECLINING AN ASSIGNMENT	A man may decline the whole assignment. It has happened twice (**FR 28**).	Part VI
THE DECLARATION	FR 20–25, as printed in Part VIII	Part VIII

Decided after this printing

LOG NO.	DATE	WHAT I DECIDED	REPLACES	PAGES AFFECTED

WHAT NO LONGER CONTROLS, AND WHERE THE FILES DISAGREE

SUPERSEDED

CONFLICT

SUPERSEDED · THE OLD COMPANION'S PRELATE	Page 182 of the old companion marked "Prelate Huldah's office" as canon. FR 33 renamed the Prelate. Huldah is only the biblical prophet.
SUPERSEDED · SOLOMON AT THIRTEEN	The timeline's age. **DECIDED** sixteen.
SUPERSEDED · DORIAN AT 61	The Crownward file's age. The ruling uses 59.
SUPERSEDED · CREST AS DORIAN'S FATHER	The Crownward file. Under FR 35, his uncle.
SUPERSEDED · FOUR PHASES	The original Trials file's Public Season and Declaration phases. The updated file has three.
CONFLICT · THE COMMONWIFE QUOTAS	Introduced under Crest in 2062 (**TL**), piloted in Red Earth in 2058 (**DOM**). **INFERENCE** A pilot under Elias, made Empire-wide under Crest.
CONFLICT · SERA CALLUM'S ORIGIN	"The Northern Dominion" (**TL**). No Dominion has that name.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION Corrections to the old companion's research run through every part, each printed where it falls under the heading "Correction to the old companion."

A CONFLICT I'VE FOUND SINCE THIS PRINTING

OPEN QUESTION

What you still have to decide

Each one appears where it belongs in the book. They're gathered here so you can work through them in one sitting.

QUESTION	PART	DECIDED?
What the Restoration Act's preamble says	V	
Who Elias's first wife was	V	
Where Sera Callum came from	V	
What the heir knew or did that made removal necessary in 2061	V	
What the "deliberate removals" in the ledger were	V	
What the Covenant of Dissent argues	V, VI	
Whether the Book of Covenant is a full Bible, abridged, or bound with the Empire's texts	IV, VI	
The Empire's official text of the Lord's Prayer	III	
What an Ungoverned citation does beyond disqualification	VI	
The six designations, their order, and where Vowed ranks	VI	
How Commonwife reassignment works, and why Solomon kept the Osei name	VI	
What Home Instruction is	VI	

What you still have to decide, continued

OPEN QUESTION

QUESTION	PART	DECIDED?
Whether the hyphenated Binding surname is Aurem's alone	VI	
Where Washington, Alaska and Hawaii are	VII	
Whether the confidentiality covenant still exists	VIII	
Who sits on the Trials Commission and the oversight committee	VIII	
Who named the Dominions, and whether it was piety or a joke	I, IV	
Whether the Temple teaches the curse of Ham	I	
Who in the Empire would authenticate the Covenant of Dissent	I, II	
Whether anyone in Dorian's court has Nathan's office	II	
What the Prelate is finally called	VI	

YOURS

LOG

The discovery log

Anything you find while working these pages starts as POSSIBLE. It moves to DECIDED only when you've decided it belongs in the manuscript, given it a number here, and noted which files it changes.

NO.	DATE	WHAT I FOUND	STATUS	FILES IT CHANGES

The discovery log, continued

NO.	DATE	WHAT I FOUND	STATUS	FILES IT CHANGES

YOURS

LOG

THE DISCOVERY LOG, CONTINUED

NO.	DATE	WHAT I FOUND	STATUS	FILES IT CHANGES

The discovery log, continued

NO.	DATE	WHAT I FOUND	STATUS	FILES IT CHANGES

SOURCE MARGIN

ALL PARTS

Where all of this came from

Every page carries a narrow source margin on its outer edge, in compressed form, author and short title. The compressed forms point to the full citations on the next pages. Nothing in a margin is a citation by itself.

RESEARCH	Unlabeled prose in Parts I to IV is research: the text says it, or the manuscript evidence shows it, and you can check it in any study Bible with a critical apparatus.
CONTESTED	Responsible scholars or traditions disagree. The dispute is printed, with the strongest case on each side, and no verdict.
INTERPRETATION · INFERENCE	A reading offered as a reading, or a conclusion drawn from your files that they don't state.
POSSIBLE	A TKC construction, about Dominion, the Temple or the manuscript, and not a claim about scripture. Test it before use.
DECIDED	A call you've made. Fixed until you rule otherwise.

ON THE SECONDARY LITERATURE

The works listed are standard reference points and not endorsements of any one position. Where two disagree, and several do sharply, the companion prints the disagreement. Several are technical commentaries that assume Hebrew or Greek. You don't need them to use this book. They're listed so every claim can be traced.

TRANSLATION I'M WORKING FROM	EDITION OR PRINTING	USED FOR

Texts, lexicons and commentaries

PART I

DOSSIERS I–IV

FOCUSED STUDIES

PART II

MT	*Biblia Hebraica Stuttgartensia*. Stuttgart: Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft. The standard printed Masoretic text. Cite the printing you use.
LXX	Rahlfs–Hanhart, *Septuaginta*. Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft. Consulted where the Greek differs from the Hebrew.
DSS	Dead Sea Scroll manuscripts cited by siglum, such as 4QDeut and 4Q365.
BDB	Brown, Driver and Briggs, *A Hebrew and English Lexicon of the Old Testament*. Oxford: Clarendon, 1906.
HALOT	Koehler and Baumgartner, *The Hebrew and Aramaic Lexicon of the Old Testament*. Leiden: Brill. The current standard. Use it over BDB where they conflict.
MILGROM	Jacob Milgrom, *Leviticus*. Anchor Bible 3, 3A, 3B. New York: Doubleday, 1991–2001.
KLAWANS	Jonathan Klawans, *Impurity and Sin in Ancient Judaism*. Oxford University Press, 2000.
DOUGLAS	Mary Douglas, *Purity and Danger*. Routledge, 1966, and *Leviticus as Literature*. Oxford, 1999.
OLYAN	Saul M. Olyan, *Disability in the Hebrew Bible*. Cambridge University Press, 2008.
BERGSMA	John Sietze Bergsma, *The Jubilee from Leviticus to Qumran*. Leiden: Brill, 2007.
WEINFELD	Moshe Weinfeld, *Deuteronomy 1–11*. Anchor Bible 5. Doubleday, 1991, and *Deuteronomy and the Deuteronomic School*. Oxford: Clarendon, 1972.
LEVINSON	Bernard M. Levinson, *Deuteronomy and the Hermeneutics of Legal Innovation*. Oxford University Press, 1997.
GOLDENBERG	David M. Goldenberg, *The Curse of Ham*. Princeton University Press, 2003.

PART I

DOSSIERS I–IV

FOCUSED STUDIES

PART II

Texts, lexicons and commentaries, continued

HAYNES	Stephen R. Haynes, *Noah's Curse*. Oxford University Press, 2002.
LEVENSON	Jon D. Levenson, *The Death and Resurrection of the Beloved Son*. Yale University Press, 1993.
TRIBLE	Phyllis Trible, *God and the Rhetoric of Sexuality* (1978) and *Texts of Terror* (1984). Fortress.
WILLIAMS	Delores S. Williams, *Sisters in the Wilderness*. Orbis, 1993.
WESTERMANN · ALTER · PROPP · CHILDS · MEYERS · JAPHET · WILLIAMSON · BLENKINSOPP · FOX · SEOW · GREENBERG · NOGALSKI · SWEENEY	The commentaries named in the focused-study and dossier margins. Record the editions you own on the last page.

Greek texts, Jesus research, ancient neighbors

PART III
PART IV
GOSPEL GRID

NA28	*Novum Testamentum Graece*, 28th revised edition. Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, 2012. Where the companion says a reading is absent from the oldest manuscripts, this is the apparatus it means.
UBS5	*The Greek New Testament*, 5th revised edition. United Bible Societies, 2014.
SANDERS	E. P. Sanders, *The Historical Figure of Jesus*. Penguin, 1993.
EHRMAN	Bart D. Ehrman, *The New Testament: A Historical Introduction*. Oxford University Press. Record your edition, since page references move.
GOODACRE	Mark Goodacre, *The Case Against Q*. Trinity Press International, 2002.
BORG AND CROSSAN	Marcus Borg and John Dominic Crossan, *The Last Week*. HarperOne, 2006.
LEVINE	Amy-Jill Levine, *The Misunderstood Jew*. HarperOne, 2006.
EPP	Eldon Jay Epp, *Junia: The First Woman Apostle*. Fortress, 2005.
COS	William W. Hallo and K. Lawson Younger, eds., *The Context of Scripture*. Brill, 1997–2002. The flood parallels, the Mesha inscription and the law codes.
SAA 2	Simo Parpola and Kazuko Watanabe, *Neo-Assyrian Treaties and Loyalty Oaths*. Helsinki University Press, 1988. The succession-treaty curses compared with Deuteronomy 28.
STEYMANS	Hans Ulrich Steymans, *Deuteronomium 28 und die adê zur Thronfolgeregelung Asarhaddons*. 1995.
MENDENHALL · MORAN	George Mendenhall, "Covenant Forms in Israelite Tradition" (1954–55). William Moran, "The Ancient Near Eastern Background of the Love of God in Deuteronomy" (1963).

PART IV, V

LINKS TO CLICK THROUGH AT PROOFING

Behind Part IV's American history

These were checked against search results. The pages themselves still need a click-through at proofing.

WINTHROP	Wikisource, *A Model of Christian Charity* · Teaching American History, "A City upon a Hill" · Museum of the Bible, "A City Upon a Hill" · Rodgers, *As a City on a Hill* (2018)
SLAVERY AND THE BIBLE	Furman University, Richard Furman's *Exposition* · Wake Forest, "Defending the Indefensible" · HathiTrust, Stringfellow's *Brief Examination* · Grimké, *Appeal to the Christian Women of the South* · Douglass, *Narrative*, Appendix · Noll, *The Civil War as a Theological Crisis* (2006)
THE SOUTHERN BAPTIST CONVENTION	*Christianity Today* on the 1995 resolution · the SBC Racial Reconciliation Resolution · Baptist News Global
THE 1807 SLAVE BIBLE	NPR, December 9, 2018 · Wikipedia, *Select Parts of the Holy Bible*
THE BLACK CHURCH	Raboteau, *Slave Religion* (1978) · Lincoln and Mamiya, *The Black Church in the African American Experience* (1990) · Wikipedia, Richard Allen and Emanuel AME · BlackPast · Equal Justice Initiative, July 2, 1822
CHRISTIAN NATIONALISM	PRRI and Brookings, February 2023 · Whitehead and Perry, *Taking America Back for God* (2020) · Mark David Hall · Wolfe, *The Case for Christian Nationalism* (2022)
RECONSTRUCTIONISM	Rushdoony, *The Institutes of Biblical Law* (1973) · Bahnsen, *Theonomy in Christian Ethics* (1977) · Barker and Godfrey, eds., *Theonomy: A Reformed Critique* (1990) · Chalcedon
DOMINIONISM AND THE SEVEN MOUNTAINS	Diamond, *Spiritual Warfare* (1989) · Northeastern University, November 15, 2022 · Wikipedia, Seven Mountain Mandate · Good Faith Media · *Christian Post* · Taylor, *The Violent Take It by Force* (2024)
DANVERS AND CBE	Wikipedia, Council on Biblical Manhood and Womanhood · CBE, "A Brief History" · *Christianity Today*, July 2011

Editions I actually own

YOURS

PROOFING

WORK	EDITION AND YEAR	CHECKED

WHAT'S STILL OUTSTANDING

Page-level references. The lists identify the works behind each claim and don't yet give a page for every one. Adding them is a proofing task, and every dossier's proofing gate carries it until it's done.

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